

Sri Lanka



Area 25,332 sq miles
(65,610 sq km)
Population 21 million
Capital Colombo
Currency Sri Lankan rupee
Official languages Sinhala
and Tamil
Life expectancy 75 years

The teardrop-shaped island of Sri Lanka, formerly known as Ceylon, is separated from India by the Palk Strait. Sri Lanka's domestic peace was marred by civil war between the majority Buddhist Sinhalese and the minority Hindu Tamils. The conflicts ended in 2009, when the army defeated the Tamil Tiger rebel group.

China



Area 3,705,407 sq miles
(9,596,960 sq km)
Population 1.35 billion
Capital Beijing
Currency Yuan
Official language Mandarin
Life expectancy 72 years

▼ HONG KONG'S SKYLINE

With its skyscrapers and shopping malls, Hong Kong is one of the world's most modern cities. Controlled for a time by the UK, it came back under Chinese administration in 1997.

Mongolia



Area 604,249 sq miles
(1,565,000 sq km)
Population 2.8 million
Capital Ulan Bator
Currency Tugrik
Official language Khalka
Mongolian
Life expectancy 67 years

Mongolia lies landlocked between Siberia and China. Its various nomadic tribes were first unified by Genghis Khan in 1206. In 1990, Mongolia abandoned Communist rule and became a multiparty democracy. Mongolia has vast mineral resources, such as coal and oil. Its economy is being driven by the fast-growing mining industry.



▲ MONGOLIAN HAT

The traditional silk-and-velvet hat with a topknot is worn by Mongolian men during celebrations, weddings, and other ceremonies.

Covering a vast area of eastern Asia and bordered by 14 countries, the People's Republic of China is home to one-fifth of the world's population. The vast majority is Han Chinese, while the rest is made up of 55 minority ethnic groups. From the founding of the Communist People's Republic in 1949, China was dominated by Chairman Mao Zedong until his death in 1976. China's Communist Party is the world's largest political party, and holds absolute authority over its people.

Despite past domestic troubles, China has become an industrial and nuclear power. Today, China is a rapidly developing economy and has overtaken the US as the world's biggest manufacturer. China also plays an important role in the mineral trade—it is the biggest producer of steel and tungsten, and has the largest deposits of more than a dozen minerals. China also has ambitious space exploration programs and plans to launch a space station by 2020.

